

QUALIFIERS

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Searching for a solution: Igor Stimac (left) faces numerous challenges in improving the Indian midfield, including the scarcity of center-forwards apart from Sunil Chhetri (right). RITU RAJ KONWAR

to come. As for Brandon, his recent form in the ISL bodes well for the national team ahead of the World Cup qualifiers in June.

For the 41-man probables list, Stimac had rewarded Kerala Blasters' Vibin Mohanan with a call-up after his excellent breakout campaign, but he was ultimately trimmed from the final squad. One player Stimac seemed to have overlooked recently is Lalthathanga Khawlhing, also known as Puitea. Playing alongside someone of the quality of Jahouh has helped revitalise the diminutive central midfielder, who moved from Mohun Bagan to Odisha this summer. He was the best passing Indian midfielder this season with 919 completed passes, 683 more than his previous season's count with the Mariners, having played nine additional matches.

Passing isn't the only metric that determines the quality of a midfielder. To become a complete midfielder, one should also excel in positioning, tackling, aerial duels, and interceptions. Puitea, with a dribbling ability that's unique among

Indian deep-lying midfielders, has had his best campaign this year. However, he is yet to earn a senior India cap. His only call-up in the last 12 months was in March ahead of the Afghanistan World Cup qualifier. He was included in the probables list, but the 26-year-old was cut from the eventual squad.

Often, when pitted against higher-ranked opponents, India has come unstuck due to its inability to progress the ball from the back to the front or control phases of play. Central midfielders with a wide passing range, who can play themselves out of tight spaces, could solve some of these problems.

If India hopes to secure any points in the upcoming qualifiers and aims to achieve World Cup third-round qualification, it could utilise Puitea alongside Lalengmawia in the double pivot role. But Stimac's preference for aerial strength in the form of Jeakson seems to go against the Odisha midfielder.

Apart from them, youngsters like Jiteshwor Singh and Ayush Adhikari (Chennaiyin), Nikhil Prabhu (Punjab

FC), Mark Zothanpuia and Lalchhanhima Sailo (Hyderabad), Harsh Patre (Bengaluru), Abhishek Suryavanshi (Mohun Bagan) — all of whom are aged under 24 and have played over 800 minutes — have impressed, but most of them play for clubs that finished in the bottom half of the table.

The youthful profile of an Indian midfielder and the limited playing time in midfield positions in the top division doesn't augur well for Stimac and the national team.

Mumbai City's title-winning coach Petr Kratky said after winning the ISL trophy, "I was talking to our sports director and said I would want to win the ISL trophy with only Indian players. But there is no denying that foreign players bring quality and experience that Indians can learn from."

While foreigners like Jahouh and Noguera rightly bring in the know-how to help Indian midfielders, the reason for the league's existence will become moot if Indians don't get the space to develop their game and reach greater heights.